defence self-reliance. It would undermine the strategic objective of a strong India–US partnership in the Indo-Pacific. Prime Minister Modi's Shangri La address and the Act Far East initiative demonstrated a multilayered Indian approach to dealing with China in the Indo-Pacific, which would seek to involve both the United States and Russia.

Critical geopolitical questions

The viability of India's dual-track approach with the United States and Russia will be tested by Russia's response to its external and domestic challenges and the configuration of the US–Russia–China triangle.

The Trump administration has mounted relentless pressure on Russia through extra-territorial secondary sanctions, expanding US influence in an arc on Russia's periphery (from the Baltic Sea to Central Asia, through Ukraine, Black Sea, Caucasus, and Caspian Sea), and increasing Russia's defence costs by withdrawal from the INF Treaty.

Russia has responded with aggressive militarisation, a "pivot" to Asia, and using all other available levers to sustain its self-image as a global power. It remains the second-strongest nuclear weapons power and a permanent member of the UN Security Council, exercising its veto to thwart initiatives against its interests. Though the United States has used its formidable clout to push for the political and economic boycott of Russia, most major countries maintain functional relations with Russia. Despite sanctions, many European countries have seen double-digit growth in trade and investment links with Russia during 2017–18. They have been in contact with President Putin on Ukraine, Syria, and Afghanistan. European leaders, of France and Germany in particular, continue to make strenuous efforts to